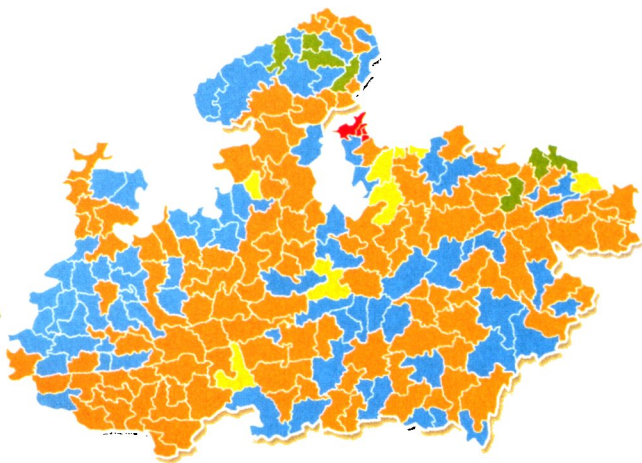


MADHYA PRADESH

ASSEMBLY POLL 08



PRASHANT CHAUDHARY

RESULT	2008	2003
■ CONG	70	38
■ BJP	144	173
■ BSP	7	2
■ SP	1	7
OTHERS	8	8

Total number of seats: 230

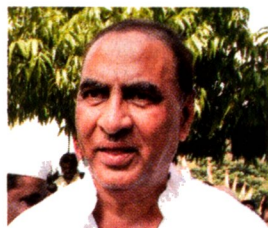
7

is the
number of
seats won
by the BSP.

33%

incumbent
MLAs were
dropped by
the BJP.

BITING THE DUST



SUBHASH YADAV

The former deputy chief minister and ex-PCC president, former assembly speaker Srinivas Tiwari and former deputy speaker of the state assembly Hazarilal Raghuvanshi were among the surprise Congress losers.



UMA BHARATI

Time is running out for the rebel BJP leader and former chief minister who put her own reputation on the line in her home district Tikamgarh and lost by over 9,000 votes to Yadendra Singh of the Congress.

Chouhan sidestepped national issues like terrorism and runaway inflation and harped on issues that concerned the state.

the "politics of personal touch". As his unique schemes for women and girl child redefined the lexicon of state-sponsored welfare, the voters forgot everything about their *bijli*, *sadak*, *paani* woes and the results exceeded even his own party's wildest imagination.

The Chouhan formula of cannily targeting sops at different gender, social, economic and caste groups robbed the state budget of its sheen for three years. But the over two dozen panchayats that Chouhan held at his residence to announce sops for SCs, STs, tribals, farmers, women and the upper caste poor continued to add to his stature. By election time, Chouhan had a larger-than-life persona. People didn't show up at the public meetings of national leaders but flocked to his whirlwind tours that included over 150 public meetings. He mainly harped on the development theme, sidestepping national issues like terror or inflation. Very early into the campaign, he realised the folly of engaging with the controversy surrounding Sadhvi Pragya Singh Thakur's arrest in the Malegaon blast case.

Perhaps the smartest move that Chouhan made was to persuade the BJP's central leadership to drop as many as a third of its incumbent MLAs who had become hugely unpopular in their constituencies. It worked wonders as most of the fresh faces won. However, apart from his early projection as chief ministerial candidate, a host of other factors ensured a favourable poll outcome. The party's campaign strategy hinged on meticulous planning that began as early as February, when over at the Congress, Suresh Pachauri was taking his first tentative steps as the new Madhya Pradesh Congress Committee president.

With BJP elders in Madhya Pradesh like former chief ministers Sunderlal Patwa and Kailash Joshi in semi-retirement and other seniors reined in by Delhi, there was little challenge for the young BJP team to put its own plans into place. Despite Chouhan's high public approval ratings, the party had lost a number of by-elections in the state last year. In any case, he was more at ease on road shows, without much inclination for backroom planning or preparations. It was left to the former RSS *pracharak* Anil Madhav Dave to work out the nitty gritty of political trends, the voter mood and devise a campaign strategy. State BJP President Narendra Singh Tomar aligned the party organisation to the campaign strategy, touring the state endlessly to stamp out dissent and energise the workers. After initial hiccups, the party was able to trot out a well-oiled election machinery. And the results have left the Congress shell-shocked to say the least.

The grand old party's refusal to project a chief ministerial candidate and its formula of the '80s of relying on regional satraps to pull through have been shown up as grossly inadequate when parties like the BJP and even the BSP were on their toes and working out different political formulae. The Congress paid heavily for the severe